



This book describes, discusses, and pays tribute to some of the movies that best capture the wonder of cinema. The movies gathered here are those that the authors feel, in the imprecise way of these things, to have had the most seismic impact on both cinema and the world.

The journey starts in 1902, when Parisian showman Georges Méliès unveiled the latest in the series of short silent movies with which he had been entertaining his countrymen. It was a romp through space called *A Trip to the Moon* (*Le voyage dans la lune*), and it was a huge and instant success—not just in France but across the world. (Sadly for Méliès, much of that success was due to the movie

“I don’t know yet what I’m going to tell them. It’ll be pretty close to the truth.”

Philip Marlowe / *The Big Sleep*

being incessantly pirated by rivals.) Its popularity did more than any other movie of the time to secure the movie as the premier art form of the age. None before it had been as spectacular; none had such an intricate storyline.

Trains, panic, and hype

By the time Méliès was making his lunar adventure, cinema had already been established as a slightly disreputable pastime, to be enjoyed at theaters and fairgrounds. To find its true beginnings, it is necessary to step back further—to Paris again, but this time with two showmen in the spotlight. The pair, brothers Auguste and Louis Lumière, had their moment in 1896. That was when, after holding large-scale screenings of their movies the year before, they first showed the French public *L’arrivée d’un train en gare de La Ciotat*—also known as *The Arrival of a Train*. It was a mere 50 seconds of footage in which, as the title suggests, a steam train entered La Ciotat station, shot from the adjacent

platform. The sight sent all those watching fleeing in panic, convinced they were about to be mowed down by the speeding locomotive—or at least that’s the story that circulated after the event. The exact truth has been lost to time, but either the Lumières had quickly mastered the new art form’s ability to make the screen feel like life, or they had a stunning knack for promotional hype. Perhaps it doesn’t matter either way—both those skills have a central place in the story of cinema.

But it may be necessary to step back further still. After all, before the Lumière brothers sent their audience bolting in terror, plenty of others had pioneered movies. There should be a tip of the hat to US inventor Thomas Edison, who had screened movies of boxing cats and men sneezing to individual customers a couple of years before the Lumières, and to English photographer Eadweard Muybridge, whose 1880s studies of humans and animals in motion were a vital preface to the moving picture.

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No matter where the cinema goes, we cannot afford to lose sight of its beginnings.

Martin Scorsese

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